

A Somos-Type Constraint on Hankel Determinants and Jacobi Recurrence Coefficients

Thomas Scheuerle

Michael Somos

September 14, 2026 (revised)

Abstract

Assuming that a sequence arises as the shifted Hankel transform of the coefficient sequence of a Stieltjes continued fraction, we translate a Somos-type quartic relation into a constraint on the recurrence coefficients of the associated monic orthogonal polynomials. We prove a characterization: the shifted Hankel determinants satisfy the Somos-type relation if and only if consecutive off-diagonal Jacobi coefficients satisfy a fixed symmetric biquadratic equation. Equivalently, the Somos constraint imposes an algebraic law on successive ratios of squared norms. The diagonal Jacobi coefficients do not occur in this condition. We also give a corrected five-parameter quadratic algebraic generating function whose coefficient Hankel determinants realize the Somos-4 family $A(1, \tau)$ with prescribed initial determinants (λ, m, r, η) . Its construction is derived from a paired-Hankel reconstruction of a Stieltjes fraction and a quadratic closure of the recurrent tail. The once-shifted coefficient sequence has companion Hankel determinants $\widehat{H}_n = H_{n+2}$, so removal of the constant coefficient advances the Somos orbit by two determinant indices. This is an identity of Hankel transforms, not in general an identity between independently parameterized generating functions. Finally, we place Hankel determinants, Jacobi coefficients, convergent amplitudes, and the QRT first integral in one tau-function hierarchy.

Preface and motivation

This note originated from a rather specific question concerning Somos-4 sequences and, in particular, from an exchange with Michael Somos about computations involving rational Somos-4 sequences.

The immediate starting point was the observation that the general Somos-4 recurrence is a rational recurrence. Given arbitrary nonzero initial values, there is no reason for the resulting terms to remain integral; rational values are in fact the natural generic situation. The remarkable phenomenon is rather the opposite one: for certain special integer initial conditions, the recurrence produces integers indefinitely. This distinction led to a simple question: what structure remains visible if one deliberately does not restrict attention to the exceptional integral solutions?

The question arose in connection with an experiment using the two elementary transformations which replace one member of a four-term Somos-4 seed by the other root of the corresponding quadratic relation. Starting from four consecutive terms of the classical Somos-4 sequence

$$1, 1, 2, 3,$$

with parameters

$$p_1 = p_2 = 1, \quad p_4 = 4,$$

these transformations generate alternative four-term seeds having the same Somos parameters. Iterating the transformations therefore provides a convenient way of exploring different rational orbits belonging to the same underlying Somos-4 family.

In the course of this experiment, an unexpected connection appeared with OEIS A377264, a sequence arising from a nonlinear recurrence for coefficients of a Stieltjes continued fraction. This suggested looking at the problem from a direction somewhat different from the usual treatments of Somos sequences.

There is already a rich theory surrounding Somos–4 recurrences, including the Laurent phenomenon, elliptic curves and elliptic divisibility sequences, theta functions, and combinatorial interpretations; see, for example, Fomin and Zelevinsky [5] and Hone and Swart [6]. The purpose here is not to reproduce or compete with those developments. Instead, we deliberately take a different route. The central object is the Somos biquadratic relation

$$a_1^2 a_4^2 + p_1 a_1 a_3^3 + p_1 a_2^3 a_4 + p_2 a_2^2 a_3^2 - p_4 a_1 a_2 a_3 a_4 = 0,$$

viewed not primarily as an elliptic or combinatorial object, but as a relation which may be transported through continued fractions, Hankel determinants, moment functionals, and orthogonal polynomials.

This viewpoint leads naturally to the ratios

$$u_n = \frac{a_{n-1} a_{n+1}}{a_n^2}.$$

For shifted Hankel determinants these ratios have an independent interpretation: they are precisely the off-diagonal coefficients of the associated monic Jacobi recurrence. The Somos biquadratic relation therefore becomes a direct algebraic constraint on consecutive Jacobi coefficients. This observation is the main starting point of the present note.

The connection with continued fractions is particularly useful because it also explains why nonlinear recurrences for individual Stieltjes coefficients can produce Somos sequences after contraction. The example associated with A377264 provides a concrete instance in which the continued-fraction coefficients, their contracted Jacobi coefficients, the Hankel determinants, and the resulting elliptic dynamics can all be seen within the same construction.

The development that follows should therefore be read partly as an exploration. Some of the results are elementary characterizations, while later sections investigate the integrable structure suggested by them. In particular, the resulting two-dimensional map has a symmetric biquadratic invariant, is symplectic and reversible, and possesses genus-one invariant curves. This naturally raises the question of whether the continued-fraction level admits a lift to a Volterra- or modified-Volterra-type transformation. That latter direction is left explicitly as a conjectural one.

The present version also has something of the character of a research notebook. It grew out of the attempt to understand several connections which were not apparent at the beginning, and some of the organization reflects that history. Nevertheless, the individual statements and calculations are presented independently of that correspondence, with the intention that the mathematical content should stand on its own.

The motivating correspondence also served as a useful reminder that there is value in examining a familiar structure outside its most celebrated special cases. In the present setting, the rational solutions are not a nuisance to be removed in favor of the integral ones; they provide the generic setting in which the underlying algebraic and dynamical structure becomes visible. This note is an attempt to follow that structure.

1 Introduction

The purpose of this note is to identify the orthogonal-polynomial content of a Somos-type quartic relation satisfied by shifted Hankel determinants. The main result is a characterization in terms of the off-diagonal coefficients in the three-term recurrence for the monic orthogonal polynomials

of the normalized shifted moment functional. More precisely, if these coefficients are denoted by $\widehat{b}_n$, then the quartic recurrence for the determinants is equivalent to the biquadratic relation

$$\widehat{b}_n^2 \widehat{b}_{n+1}^2 - p_4 \widehat{b}_n \widehat{b}_{n+1} + p_1 (\widehat{b}_n + \widehat{b}_{n+1}) + p_2 = 0$$

for all relevant indices. No diagonal coefficient $\widehat{d}_n$ appears. Since $\widehat{b}_n$ is also the ratio of two consecutive squared norms, the same equation gives an algebraic law for successive norm ratios. Liu, Wang, and Zhang [11] study sufficient conditions under which Hankel transforms of generating functions satisfy (α, β) Somos-4 identities. They also use the standard quotient variables

$$x_n = \frac{S_{n-1} S_{n+1}}{S_n^2}$$

and their rational first integral in the analysis of even and odd subsequences. The purpose of the present note is different. Assuming that the terms are first-shifted Hankel determinants of a Stieltjes moment sequence, we identify these quotient variables with the off-diagonal Jacobi coefficients of the normalized shifted moment functional. This yields an if-and-only-if characterization of the Somos identity as a symmetric biquadratic constraint on consecutive Jacobi coefficients. In particular, the diagonal Jacobi coefficients are absent from, and remain unrestricted by, the Somos constraint.

2 The quartic relation

Let $(a_n)_{n \geq 1}$ satisfy

$$a_{n-3}^2 a_n^2 + p_1 a_{n-3} a_{n-1}^3 + p_1 a_{n-2}^3 a_n + p_2 a_{n-2}^2 a_{n-1}^2 - p_4 a_{n-3} a_{n-2} a_{n-1} a_n = 0. \quad (1)$$

Here p_1, p_2, p_4 are fixed parameters. The entries may lie in $\mathbb{R}, \mathbb{C}$, or a suitable commutative field; no integrality assumption is made.

3 Stieltjes continued fraction and moments

Classical connections among continued fractions, moments, and Hankel determinants are discussed by Wall [2] and Flajolet [4]. Consider the formal Stieltjes continued fraction

$$S(x) = \frac{1}{1 - \frac{c_1 x}{1 - \frac{c_2 x}{1 - \frac{c_3 x}{\ddots}}}} = \sum_{n \geq 0} \mu_n x^n. \quad (2)$$

Its constant coefficient is $\mu_0 = 1$. Thus no additional coefficient c_0 is hidden in (2). If a numerator c_0 is placed in front of the fraction, then the moment sequence is merely rescaled by c_0 . We use the normalization $c_0 = 1$. For $r, m \geq 0$, define

$$\Delta_m^{(r)} = \det(\mu_{i+j+r})_{0 \leq i, j \leq m-1}, \quad \Delta_0^{(r)} = 1. \quad (3)$$

The sequence considered here is the first shifted Hankel sequence

$$a_n = \Delta_n^{(1)} \quad (n \geq 1). \quad (4)$$

For (2),

$$\Delta_n^{(1)} = c_1^n \prod_{j=1}^{n-1} (c_{2j} c_{2j+1})^{n-j}. \quad (5)$$

In particular,

$$a_1 = c_1, \quad a_2 = c_1^2 c_2 c_3, \quad a_3 = c_1^3 c_2^2 c_3^2 c_4 c_5, \quad a_4 = c_1^4 c_2^3 c_3^3 c_4^2 c_5^2 c_6 c_7. \quad (6)$$

4 Continued fraction contraction

The even contraction of (2) is

$$S(x) = \frac{1}{1 - d_0x - \frac{b_1x^2}{1 - d_1x - \frac{b_2x^2}{1 - d_2x - \ddots}}}, \quad (7)$$

where

$$d_0 = c_1, \quad d_n = c_{2n} + c_{2n+1}, \quad b_n = c_{2n-1}c_{2n} \quad (n \geq 1). \quad (8)$$

The associated monic orthogonal polynomials satisfy

$$P_{-1}(t) = 0, \quad P_0(t) = 1, \quad P_{n+1}(t) = (t - d_n)P_n(t) - b_nP_{n-1}(t). \quad (9)$$

5 The normalized shifted functional

The determinants in (4) belong to the shifted moments (μ_{n+1}) . Normalize them by setting

$$\hat{\mu}_n = \frac{\mu_{n+1}}{c_1}, \quad \hat{L}(t^n) = \hat{\mu}_n. \quad (10)$$

Let $(\hat{P}_n)$ be the monic orthogonal polynomials for $\hat{L}$ and write their recurrence as

$$\hat{P}_{-1}(t) = 0, \quad \hat{P}_0(t) = 1, \quad \hat{P}_{n+1}(t) = (t - \hat{d}_n)\hat{P}_n(t) - \hat{b}_n\hat{P}_{n-1}(t). \quad (11)$$

The shifted product formula identifies the off-diagonal coefficients as

$$\hat{b}_n = c_{2n}c_{2n+1} \quad (n \geq 1), \quad (12)$$

and consequently

$$a_n = c_1^n \prod_{j=1}^{n-1} \hat{b}_j^{n-j}. \quad (13)$$

Thus the Jacobi parameters relevant to (a_n) are the $\hat{b}_n$ of the normalized shifted functional, rather than the original $b_n = c_{2n-1}c_{2n}$.

6 The determinant-ratio reduction

Define

$$F(x, y) = x^2y^2 - p_4xy + p_1(x + y) + p_2. \quad (14)$$

Theorem 1. *Let $(a_n)_{n \geq 1}$ be nonzero, and define*

$$q_n = \frac{a_{n-1}a_{n+1}}{a_n^2} \quad (n \geq 2). \quad (15)$$

For each $n \geq 4$, the quartic relation (1) is equivalent to

$$F(q_{n-2}, q_{n-1}) = 0. \quad (16)$$

Proof. Divide (1) by $a_{n-3}a_{n-2}a_{n-1}a_n$. Using

$$q_{n-2} = \frac{a_{n-3}a_{n-1}}{a_{n-2}^2}, \quad q_{n-1} = \frac{a_{n-2}a_n}{a_{n-1}^2},$$

one obtains

$$q_{n-2}q_{n-1} + \frac{p_1}{q_{n-2}} + \frac{p_1}{q_{n-1}} + \frac{p_2}{q_{n-2}q_{n-1}} - p_4 = 0.$$

Multiplication by $q_{n-2}q_{n-1}$ gives (16). Every step is reversible under the non-vanishing assumptions. $\square$

Proposition 2. *For the shifted Hankel determinants (13),*

$$\frac{a_{n-1}a_{n+1}}{a_n^2} = \widehat{b}_n = c_{2n}c_{2n+1}. \quad (17)$$

Proof. In the quotient $a_{n-1}a_{n+1}/a_n^2$, the factors c_1 cancel. For every $j < n$, the exponent of $\widehat{b}_j$ is

$$(n-1-j) + (n+1-j) - 2(n-j) = 0,$$

while $\widehat{b}_n$ occurs once in a_{n+1} . This proves (17). $\square$

7 Characterization by the polynomial recurrence

Theorem 3 (Characterization theorem). *Let $\widehat{L}$ be a normalized quasi-definite moment functional, and let its monic orthogonal polynomials satisfy (11), with $\widehat{b}_n \neq 0$. Let (a_n) be the corresponding first shifted Hankel determinants, with the normalization in (13). Then the following are equivalent:*

1. (a_n) satisfies the Somos-type relation (1) for every $n \geq 4$;
2. the off-diagonal coefficients in the polynomial recurrence satisfy

$$F(\widehat{b}_m, \widehat{b}_{m+1}) = 0 \quad (m \geq 2), \quad (18)$$

that is,

$$\widehat{b}_m^2 \widehat{b}_{m+1}^2 - p_4 \widehat{b}_m \widehat{b}_{m+1} + p_1(\widehat{b}_m + \widehat{b}_{m+1}) + p_2 = 0. \quad (19)$$

The diagonal coefficients $\widehat{d}_n$ are unrestricted by this equivalence and do not occur in (19).

Proof. By Proposition 2, $q_m = \widehat{b}_m$. For $n \geq 4$, Theorem 1 states that (1) is equivalent to $F(q_{n-2}, q_{n-1}) = 0$. Putting $m = n - 2$ gives (18) for $m \geq 2$. Since neither the determinant product (13) nor the resulting equation contains $\widehat{d}_n$, no condition on the diagonal coefficients arises. $\square$

Remark 4. The characterization is entirely off-diagonal. Once a nonzero sequence $(\widehat{b}_n)$ satisfying (19) has been chosen, the Somos constraint itself places no additional restriction on the diagonal Jacobi parameters $(\widehat{d}_n)$. Questions of quasi-definiteness, positivity, support, and recognition of a resulting measure may impose further conditions, but these are separate from the Somos relation.

8 The associated algebraic curve and dynamics

Every pair $(\widehat{b}_m, \widehat{b}_{m+1})$, $m \geq 2$, lies on

$$C : \quad F(x, y) = 0. \quad (20)$$

The equation is symmetric in x and y and defines a reversible algebraic correspondence. Solving for y gives

$$y = \frac{p_4x - p_1 \pm \sqrt{(p_4x - p_1)^2 - 4x^2(p_1x + p_2)}}{2x^2}. \quad (21)$$

Proposition 5. *Assume $p_1 \neq 0$ and that*

$$D(x) = -4p_1x^3 + (p_4^2 - 4p_2)x^2 - 2p_1p_4x + p_1^2 \quad (22)$$

has no multiple root. Then the smooth projective model of C is a genus-one curve.

Proof. Regarding $F(x, y) = 0$ as a quadratic equation in y and introducing $z = 2x^2y + p_1 - p_4x$ gives the birational model $z^2 = D(x)$. If D is a square-free cubic, this is a nonsingular hyperelliptic curve of genus one. $\square$

Given $(x, y) \in C$, the equation $F(y, z) = 0$ has the backtracking root $z = x$. When $y \neq 0$, the other root is

$$z = \frac{p_4y - p_1}{y^2} - x.$$

Selecting this branch defines the birational map

$$T(x, y) = \left(y, \frac{p_4y - p_1}{y^2} - x \right), \quad (23)$$

where it is defined. Direct substitution shows that T preserves F . Without a branch choice, (20) is naturally a reversible algebraic correspondence; with (23), it is a birational discrete dynamical system on C .

9 Squared norms

Let

$$h_n = \widehat{L}(\widehat{P}_n^2) \quad (24)$$

be the squared norms for the normalized shifted functional. The monic three-term recurrence gives

$$h_n = \widehat{b}_n h_{n-1}, \quad \widehat{b}_n = \frac{h_n}{h_{n-1}}. \quad (25)$$

Corollary 6 (Norm-ratio characterization). *Under the hypotheses of Theorem 3, the shifted Hankel determinants satisfy (1) for every $n \geq 4$ if and only if*

$$F\left(\frac{h_m}{h_{m-1}}, \frac{h_{m+1}}{h_m}\right) = 0 \quad (m \geq 2). \quad (26)$$

Equivalently,

$$\left(\frac{h_{m+1}}{h_{m-1}}\right)^2 - p_4 \frac{h_{m+1}}{h_{m-1}} + p_1 \left(\frac{h_m}{h_{m-1}} + \frac{h_{m+1}}{h_m}\right) + p_2 = 0. \quad (27)$$

Proof. Substitute (25) into (19) and use $\widehat{b}_m \widehat{b}_{m+1} = h_{m+1}/h_{m-1}$. $\square$

10 Somos Parameters and the Associated First Integral

We use the notation $A(p_1, p_2)$ for the autonomous Somos-4 recurrence

$$a_{n+4}a_n = p_1a_{n+3}a_{n+1} + p_2a_{n+2}^2. \quad (28)$$

Equivalently, after shifting the index,

$$a_{n-2}a_{n+2} = p_1a_{n-1}a_{n+1} + p_2a_n^2.$$

Thus p_1 and p_2 are the two fixed coefficients of the Somos recurrence. They are parameters of the recurrence itself and are independent of n . The notation $A(p_1, p_2)$ will always refer to the recurrence (28), together with initial values for which the required denominators are nonzero. The classical Somos-4 recurrence is the specialization

$$A(1, 1) : \quad a_{n+4}a_n = a_{n+3}a_{n+1} + a_{n+2}^2.$$

More generally, $A(1, t)$ refers to $a_{n+4}a_n = a_{n+3}a_{n+1} + ta_{n+2}^2$. To pass from the bilinear recurrence to the Jacobi coefficients, define

$$u_n := \frac{a_{n-1}a_{n+1}}{a_n^2}, \quad (29)$$

whenever the quotient is defined. Dividing the shifted form of (28) by a_n^2 gives

$$u_{n-1}u_n^2u_{n+1} = p_1u_n + p_2. \quad (30)$$

Indeed, $u_{n-1}u_n^2u_{n+1} = a_{n-2}a_{n+2}/a_n^2$. For two consecutive values $x = u_n$ and $y = u_{n+1}$, define

$$H(x, y) = xy + p_1 \left(\frac{1}{x} + \frac{1}{y} \right) + \frac{p_2}{xy}. \quad (31)$$

Along every nonsingular orbit of (30), $H(u_n, u_{n+1})$ is independent of n . We denote this constant by p_4 :

$$p_4 = u_nu_{n+1} + p_1 \left(\frac{1}{u_n} + \frac{1}{u_{n+1}} \right) + \frac{p_2}{u_nu_{n+1}}. \quad (32)$$

The notation p_4 is chosen because this constant is associated with the fourth-order bilinear Somos recurrence. It is not a third coefficient in (28): p_1, p_2 are fixed recurrence coefficients, whereas p_4 is determined by p_1, p_2 and the initial data. Multiplying (32) by u_nu_{n+1} yields

$$u_n^2u_{n+1}^2 - p_4u_nu_{n+1} + p_1(u_n + u_{n+1}) + p_2 = 0. \quad (33)$$

Conversely,

$$u_{n+2} = \frac{p_4u_{n+1} - p_1}{u_{n+1}^2} - u_n. \quad (34)$$

Lemma 7. *Let $u_n \neq 0$ satisfy (30). Then $H(u_n, u_{n+1}) = H(u_{n-1}, u_n)$. Consequently, p_4 in (32) is independent of n .*

Proof. From (30), $u_{n-1} = (p_1u_n + p_2)/(u_n^2u_{n+1})$. Substitution into $H(u_{n-1}, u_n)$ followed by simplification gives $H(u_n, u_{n+1})$. $\square$

Remark 8. The subscript in p_4 should not be interpreted as an index of a sequence. It records the connection with Somos-4 and distinguishes the first integral from the recurrence coefficients p_1 and p_2 . Formula (32) is the definitive meaning of p_4 in this paper.

11 The Example Recorded as OEIS A377264

A concrete continued-fraction example related to the construction above is recorded in the OEIS as A377264. The OEIS entry begins with a sequence of continued-fraction coefficients $d(k)$ satisfying

$$d(k) = \frac{d(k-3)d(k-2) + 1}{d(k-5)d(k-4)d(k-3)^2d(k-2)^2d(k-1)}, \quad (35)$$

with $d(0), d(1), d(2), d(3), d(4) = 1, 1, 1, 2, 1$. The sequence A377264 itself is defined by $\text{num}(d(2n+1))$, where num denotes the numerator in lowest terms. The same OEIS entry considers the Stieltjes continued fraction

$$S(x) = \frac{1}{1 - \frac{d(0)x}{1 - \frac{d(1)x}{1 - \frac{d(2)x}{\ddots}}}} = \sum_{m \geq 0} s_m x^m. \quad (36)$$

Its Hankel transform is a shifted copy of the classical Somos-4 sequence A006720. More generally, the construction uses coefficients $c(k)$ satisfying

$$c(2k+1) = \frac{c(2k-2)c(2k-1) + t}{c(2k-4)c(2k-3)c(2k-2)^2c(2k-1)^2c(2k)}, \quad (37)$$

with a prescribed convention for negative subscripts. The associated Hankel determinants satisfy a Somos-4 recurrence of type $A(1, t)$. Three different sequences occur: the continued-fraction coefficients $d(k)$; A377264, formed from the numerators of $d(2n+1)$; and the Hankel determinants of the coefficient sequence of (36). Accordingly, A377264 should not be identified directly with either the Hankel sequence a_n or the Jacobi sequence $\hat{b}_n$. Under contraction,

$$\hat{b}_n = c_{2n}c_{2n+1}, \quad (38)$$

subject to the initial-index convention adopted for the shifted functional. Thus the Jacobi variables are products of adjacent continued-fraction coefficients, not the odd coefficients alone. In the specialization $t = 1$, the Hankel determinants satisfy $A(1, 1)$, while p_4 is determined from two consecutive nonzero Jacobi coefficients by (32).

Remark 9. The OEIS entry also describes A377264 by odd multiples of a point on an elliptic curve. This provides independent evidence that the continued-fraction recurrence, its Hankel transform, and the associated Jacobi dynamics belong to the same elliptic setting. Because the OEIS formula concerns the numerators of $d(2n+1)$, whereas the present Jacobi variables are the products $d(2n)d(2n+1)$, the two elliptic descriptions should be compared through the continued-fraction contraction rather than by direct termwise identification.

11.1 A generalized continued-fraction construction

The recurrence appearing in the OEIS construction admits a direct generalization to arbitrary Somos parameters p_1, p_2 . Let the Stieltjes coefficients c_k satisfy

$$c_{2k+1} = \frac{p_1 c_{2k-2} c_{2k-1} + p_2}{c_{2k-4} c_{2k-3} c_{2k-2}^2 c_{2k-1}^2 c_{2k}}, \quad (39)$$

with suitable prescribed initial values and with all required denominators nonzero. Define

$$u_k = c_{2k} c_{2k+1}. \quad (40)$$

Since $c_{2k-4}c_{2k-3} = u_{k-2}$ and $c_{2k-2}c_{2k-1} = u_{k-1}$, multiplication of the defining recurrence by c_{2k} gives

$$u_k = \frac{p_1 u_{k-1} + p_2}{u_{k-2} u_{k-1}^2}. \quad (41)$$

Equivalently,

$$u_{k-2} u_{k-1}^2 u_k = p_1 u_{k-1} + p_2. \quad (42)$$

Thus, after an index shift,

$$u_{n-1} u_n^2 u_{n+1} = p_1 u_n + p_2, \quad (43)$$

which is precisely the determinant-ratio recurrence associated with

$$a_{n+4} a_n = p_1 a_{n+3} a_{n+1} + p_2 a_{n+2}^2. \quad (44)$$

Consequently, the corresponding shifted Hankel determinants form a sequence of type $A(p_1, p_2)$.

The parameters p_1, p_2 do not determine the particular orbit. The additional quantity p_4 is the first integral

$$p_4 = u_n u_{n+1} + p_1 \left(\frac{1}{u_n} + \frac{1}{u_{n+1}} \right) + \frac{p_2}{u_n u_{n+1}}, \quad (45)$$

and is independent of n . Equivalently, the initial pair (u_0, u_1) must satisfy

$$u_0^2 u_1^2 - p_4 u_0 u_1 + p_1(u_0 + u_1) + p_2 = 0. \quad (46)$$

Hence, if p_1, p_2, p_4 are prescribed, one may choose an admissible nonzero value $u_0 = r$ and determine u_1 from

$$u_1 = \frac{p_4 r - p_1 \pm \sqrt{(p_4 r - p_1)^2 - 4r^2(p_1 r + p_2)}}{2r^2}. \quad (47)$$

The subsequent values are then generated by

$$u_{n+1} = \frac{p_1 u_n + p_2}{u_{n-1} u_n^2}. \quad (48)$$

Thus p_4 is incorporated through the choice of the initial point on the invariant biquadratic curve, rather than as an additional coefficient of the Somos recurrence.

11.2 Example: $p_1 = p_2 = 1$ and $p_4 = 4$

As a concrete example, consider $p_1 = p_2 = 1$ and $p_4 = 4$. The initial values satisfy

$$u_0^2 u_1^2 - 4u_0 u_1 + u_0 + u_1 + 1 = 0. \quad (49)$$

Choosing $u_0 = 1$ gives $u_1^2 - 3u_1 + 2 = 0$, and hence $u_1 = 1$ or $u_1 = 2$. The choice $u_1 = 1$ gives the constant solution $u_n = 1$. The nontrivial choice $u_0 = 1, u_1 = 2$ generates

$$u_{n+1} = \frac{u_n + 1}{u_{n-1} u_n^2}. \quad (50)$$

The first terms are

$$u_0, u_1, u_2, u_3, u_4, \dots = 1, 2, \frac{3}{4}, \frac{14}{9}, \frac{69}{49}, \dots$$

The corresponding shifted Hankel determinants therefore satisfy the classical Somos-4 recurrence

$$a_{n+4} a_n = a_{n+3} a_{n+1} + a_{n+2}^2,$$

that is, they belong to the family $A(1, 1)$.

At the level of Stieltjes coefficients, any factorization $c_{2n}c_{2n+1} = u_n$ gives the same contracted Jacobi coefficients. In particular, one may choose

$$c_{2n} = r_n, \quad c_{2n+1} = \frac{u_n}{r_n},$$

where the nonzero quantities r_n are arbitrary. This freedom does not change the sequence u_n , the associated Hankel determinants, or the value of p_4 . Thus the three levels of data can be distinguished as follows:

$$(p_1, p_2) \longrightarrow \text{Somos family},$$

$$(p_1, p_2, p_4) \longrightarrow \text{invariant elliptic curve},$$

and

$$(p_1, p_2, p_4, u_0) \longrightarrow \text{particular elliptic orbit}.$$

The remaining factorization variables r_n do not affect the contracted Jacobi dynamics.

11.3 An integral-moment gauge for the family $A(1, N)$

The factorization freedom can be used to impose an additional arithmetic condition when integral moments are desired. A concrete construction for the family $A(1, N)$ is recorded in OEIS A377441 [13]. We retain the indexing used in that entry in order to avoid conflating it with the one-based coefficients c_j of (2).

Let $d(m, N)$ be defined, with the initial convention of A377441, by

$$d(m, N) = \begin{cases} \frac{d(m-3, N)d(m-2, N) + N}{d(m-5, N)d(m-4, N)d(m-3, N)^2d(m-2, N)^2d(m-1, N)}, & m \text{ even}, \\ \frac{1}{d(m-1, N)d(m-2, N)}, & m \text{ odd}. \end{cases} \quad (51)$$

The convention for the initial indices is $d(m, N) = 1$ before the recurrence starts, as specified in the OEIS entry. The associated Stieltjes continued fraction produces the integer moment rows recorded in A377441. Its shifted Hankel determinants satisfy the Somos-4 recurrence of type $A(1, N)$.

The structurally important additional condition is the reciprocal parity rule

$$d(m, N)d(m-1, N)d(m-2, N) = 1 \quad (m \text{ odd}). \quad (52)$$

This condition is not imposed by the Somos recurrence. Rather, it fixes the otherwise free factorization at every second step. In the notation of the present paper, the contracted quantities remain products of adjacent Stieltjes coefficients, whereas the reciprocal parity rule selects particular individual factors above that contracted orbit.

To see the distinction, suppose that a contracted coefficient is written as

$$u_n = c_{2n}c_{2n+1}.$$

Without an additional condition, one may choose

$$c_{2n} = r_n, \quad c_{2n+1} = \frac{u_n}{r_n}$$

with arbitrary nonzero r_n . An A377441-type reciprocal relation removes this arbitrariness recursively. The projected Jacobi dynamics and the shifted Hankel determinants are preserved, but the selected moment sequence is changed. For $A(1, N)$, the construction in A377441 selects a representative having integral moments even though its individual continued-fraction coefficients are generally rational.

Thus moment integrality is not a consequence of the Somos relation alone, nor of integrality of the individual Stieltjes coefficients. It is an additional property of the chosen lift from the contracted Jacobi coefficients to the continued-fraction coefficients. For the family $A(1, N)$, the recurrence above supplies an explicit optional constraint that enforces this arithmetic choice.

Remark 10. The indexing of A377441 and the indexing of the shifted determinants in the present paper differ by initial terms. Accordingly, the continued-fraction coefficients and the contracted products should be compared only after applying the corresponding shift. The arithmetic statement is unaffected: the A377441 construction gives an integral moment sequence whose Hankel transform belongs to the family $A(1, N)$.

12 Direct algebraic realization of prescribed Somos–4 Hankel data

This part incorporates the corrected inverse construction developed in the companion working note. In particular, the coefficient tail has a companion Hankel transform advanced by *two* determinant indices, the Stieltjes coefficients are recovered from paired ordinary and once-shifted Hankel data, and the algebraic generating function is derived by quadratic closure of the recurrent continued-fraction tail.

12.1 Hankel determinants and Somos parameters

Let

$$G(z) = \sum_{n \geq 0} g_n z^n$$

be a formal power series, and for $n \geq 1$ define its ordinary Hankel determinants by

$$H_n = \det(g_{i+j})_{0 \leq i, j \leq n-1}, \quad H_0 = 1. \quad (53)$$

The five parameters $\lambda, m, r, \eta, \tau$ have the following roles:

$$H_1 = \lambda, \quad H_2 = m, \quad H_3 = r, \quad H_4 = \eta, \quad (54)$$

and the Hankel sequence satisfies the Somos–4 recurrence

$$H_{n+4}H_n = H_{n+3}H_{n+1} + \tau H_{n+2}^2, \quad n \geq 1. \quad (55)$$

Thus τ is the second coefficient of the Somos family $A(1, \tau)$, whereas λ, m, r , and η select the initial Hankel determinants. The algebraic generating function producing these determinants is given in the next section. The construction makes one additional choice that is easy to overlook: together with $(H_n)_{n \geq 0}$, it fixes the companion Hankel sequence

$$\hat{H}_n = \det(g_{i+j+1})_{0 \leq i, j \leq n-1} = H_{n+2} \quad (n \geq 1). \quad (56)$$

Thus the companion is obtained by advancing the Somos–4 orbit by two indices without applying any additional normalization factor. Its first term is $\hat{H}_1 = g_1 = H_3 = r$, not $H_2 = m$. This second prescription is part of the definition of the selected coefficient sequence; it is not a consequence of the ordinary Hankel determinants alone. Section 12.8 explains why prescribing both sequences removes the degree of freedom discussed there.

12.2 Behind the construction: the Stieltjes fraction

The quadratic equation below may be obtained by first constructing a Stieltjes continued fraction whose Hankel determinants follow the prescribed Somos–4 orbit. Write

$$G(x) = \frac{c_0}{1 - \frac{c_1 x}{1 - \frac{c_2 x}{1 - \frac{c_3 x}{\ddots}}}}. \quad (57)$$

For this normalization, the ordinary Hankel determinants are [33, 26, 4]

$$H_n = c_0^n \prod_{j=1}^{n-1} (c_{2j-1} c_{2j})^{n-j}. \quad (58)$$

Thus

$$H_1 = c_0, \quad H_2 = c_0^2 c_1 c_2, \quad H_3 = c_0^3 c_1^2 c_2^2 c_3 c_4,$$

and similarly at higher orders.

It is useful first to remove the exponential scaling caused by H_1 . Set

$$a_1 = 1, \quad a_2 = \frac{m}{\lambda^2}, \quad a_3 = \frac{r}{\lambda^3}, \quad a_4 = \frac{\eta}{\lambda^4}. \quad (59)$$

Then $H_n = \lambda^n a_n$ for $1 \leq n \leq 4$, and the normalized sequence (a_n) obeys the same Somos–4 recurrence,

$$a_{n+4} a_n = a_{n+3} a_{n+1} + \tau a_{n+2}^2, \quad n \geq 1. \quad (60)$$

The powers of λ in (59) are essential: for nonunit $H_1 = \lambda$, the correct normalization is $a_j = H_j / \lambda^j$, not H_j / λ^{j-1} .

A convenient initial segment of the Stieltjes coefficients is

$$c_0 = \lambda, \quad c_1 = \lambda^2 a_3, \quad c_2 = \frac{a_2}{\lambda^2 a_3}, \quad (61)$$

$$c_3 = \frac{a_4}{a_2 a_3}, \quad c_4 = \frac{a_3^2}{a_2 a_4}, \quad c_5 = \tau \frac{a_2 a_3}{a_4} + \frac{a_2^2}{a_3}. \quad (62)$$

Equivalently, in the parameters used throughout this paper,

$$\begin{aligned} c_0 &= \lambda, & c_1 &= \frac{r}{\lambda}, & c_2 &= \frac{m}{\lambda r}, \\ c_3 &= \frac{\lambda \eta}{mr}, & c_4 &= \frac{r^2}{m\eta}, & c_5 &= \frac{\tau mr}{\lambda \eta} + \frac{m^2}{\lambda r}. \end{aligned} \quad (63)$$

The remaining coefficients are generated alternately by

$$c_{2k} = \frac{1}{c_{2k-2} c_{2k-1}}, \quad c_{2k+1} = c_{2k-2} + \frac{\tau}{c_{2k-1}} \quad (k \geq 3). \quad (64)$$

In particular,

$$c_6 = \frac{1}{c_4 c_5}, \quad c_7 = c_4 + \frac{\tau}{c_5}, \quad c_8 = \frac{1}{c_6 c_7}, \quad c_9 = c_6 + \frac{\tau}{c_7}.$$

Substitution in (58) gives $H_j = \lambda^j a_j$ for $1 \leq j \leq 4$. At the next order it gives

$$\frac{H_5}{\lambda^5} = \frac{a_3 a_4 c_5}{a_2} = a_2 a_4 + \tau a_3^2,$$

which is exactly the first Somos-4 step. The alternating recurrence (64) continues this mechanism.

The standard once-shifted Hankel product formula [28] for the Stieltjes fraction is

$$\hat{H}_n = (c_0 c_1)^n \prod_{j=1}^{n-1} (c_{2j} c_{2j+1})^{n-j} \quad (n \geq 1). \quad (65)$$

Together with (58), this formula gives a direct reconstruction result.

12.2.1 Paired-Hankel reconstruction

Let F be a field, let $H_0 = K_0 = 1$, and suppose $H_n K_n \neq 0$ for $n \geq 1$. There is a unique nondegenerate Stieltjes fraction of the form (57) whose ordinary and once-shifted Hankel determinants are H_n and K_n , respectively. Its coefficients are

$$c_0 = H_1, \quad c_{2n-1} = \frac{H_{n-1} K_n}{H_n K_{n-1}}, \quad c_{2n} = \frac{H_{n+1} K_{n-1}}{H_n K_n} \quad (n \geq 1). \quad (66)$$

Indeed, taking adjacent determinant ratios in (58) and (65) and telescoping alternately gives (66). Conversely, substitution of these coefficients into the two product formulae telescopes back to H_n and K_n . Nonvanishing makes every division legitimate and proves uniqueness in the S-fraction chart.

In the present construction $K_0 = 1$ and $K_n = H_{n+2}$ only for $n \geq 1$. Thus $c_1 = H_3/H_1$, $c_2 = H_2/(H_1 H_3)$, and, for $n \geq 2$,

$$c_{2n-1} = \frac{H_{n-1} H_{n+2}}{H_n H_{n+1}}, \quad c_{2n} = \frac{H_{n+1}^2}{H_n H_{n+2}}. \quad (67)$$

These identities recover (63) and (64). They also prove for every positive order that

$$\det(g_{i+j+1})_{0 \leq i, j \leq n-1} = H_{n+2} \quad (n \geq 1). \quad (68)$$

In particular, $g_1 = c_0 c_1 = r$. Thus the ordinary determinants fix only the products $c_{2j-1} c_{2j}$, whereas the companion determinants fix their splitting into odd and even coefficients. This gives the particular representative used throughout the paper. The formulas are classical in substance; their role here is to make the all-index determinant assertions and the qualified uniqueness statement explicit. The next step is to eliminate the recursively defined continued-fraction tail. The following isolated calculation explains why this elimination closes quadratically and hence provides the conceptual bridge to the explicit equation in Section 12.3.

12.2.2 Quadratic closure of the recurrent tail

For a sequence $(d_n)_{n \geq 1}$, write

$$T_n(x) = \frac{1}{1 - \frac{d_n x}{1 - \frac{d_{n+1} x}{1 - \ddots}}}, \quad T_n = \frac{1}{1 - d_n x T_{n+1}}. \quad (69)$$

The recurrence in (64) becomes transparent after the tail is started at c_4 . Put

$$d_n = c_{n+3}, \quad b = d_1 = c_4, \quad d = d_2 = c_5, \quad t = \tau. \quad (70)$$

Then $d_1 = b$, $d_2 = d$, $d_3 = 1/(bd)$, and thereafter

$$d_n = \frac{1}{d_{n-1} d_{n-2}} \quad (n \geq 3 \text{ odd}), \quad d_n = \frac{t}{d_{n-2}} + d_{n-3} \quad (n \geq 4 \text{ even}). \quad (71)$$

Thus the alternating recurrence can be studied independently of the first three levels of the original Stieltjes fraction.

Proposition 11 (Quadratic equation for the recurrent tail). *Let $T = T_1$ be the formal continued fraction defined by (69)–(71). Then $T(0) = 1$ and*

$$\mathcal{A}(x)T^2 + \mathcal{B}(x)T + \mathcal{C}(x) = 0, \quad (72)$$

where

$$\mathcal{A}(x) = (bt + 1)x - b((b + d)t + 1)x^2, \quad (73)$$

$$\mathcal{B}(x) = bdt x^2 + (-bt + b^2d + d^2b - 1)x - bd, \quad (74)$$

$$\mathcal{C}(x) = bd - bd^2x. \quad (75)$$

Proof. Removing one level of a Stieltjes fraction is a fractional-linear transformation,

$$T_{n+1} = \frac{T_n - 1}{d_n x T_n}. \quad (76)$$

Consequently, quadratic relations are preserved under tail extraction. More explicitly, if $Q_n(Y)$ is quadratic and $Q_n(T_n) = 0$, then a polynomial for the next tail is

$$Q_{n+1}(Y) = (1 - d_n x Y)^2 Q_n\left(\frac{1}{1 - d_n x Y}\right), \quad (77)$$

For the quadratic in (72), write $Q_{b,d}(x, Y) = \mathcal{A}(x)Y^2 + \mathcal{B}(x)Y + \mathcal{C}(x)$ and set

$$b' = \frac{1}{bd}, \quad d' = b + \frac{t}{d}.$$

A direct expansion gives the exact covariance identity

$$(1 - bx - dxZ)^2 Q_{b,d}\left(x, \frac{1 - dxZ}{1 - bx - dxZ}\right) = \frac{b^3 d^4 x^2}{bd + t} Q_{1/(bd), b+t/d}(x, Z). \quad (78)$$

For the recurrent tails,

$$T_1 = \frac{1 - dxT_3}{1 - bx - dxT_3}.$$

The recurrence (71) maps the parameter pair (b, d) for T_1 to $(1/(bd), b + t/d)$ for T_3 . Iterating (78) therefore shows, for every N , that $Q_{b,d}(x, T_1)$ is divisible by x^{2N} in $\mathbb{Q}(b, d, t)[[x]]$. Hence it vanishes identically. Finally, $Q_{b,d}(0, Y) = bd(1 - Y)$, so the formal branch satisfying $T_1(0) = 1$ is unique. $\square$

This proposition gives a short derivation of the algebraic nature of the full generating function. Let $T = T_4$ denote the tail of (57) beginning with c_4 . The first three levels are recovered by

$$T_3 = \frac{1}{1 - c_3 x T}, \quad T_2 = \frac{1}{1 - c_2 x T_3}, \quad T_1 = \frac{1}{1 - c_1 x T_2}, \quad G = c_0 T_1. \quad (79)$$

Each step is again a Möbius transformation. Substituting (79) into (72), followed by $c_0 = \lambda$ and the values in (63), therefore produces a quadratic polynomial in G . Clearing denominators and collecting powers of z yields exactly the polynomials in (83)–(90). This explains structurally why the recursively defined infinite fraction gives a quadratic algebraic generating function: the recurrence is the compatibility condition that keeps the continued-fraction tails inside a quadratic family, while the omitted initial levels only conjugate that family by fractional-linear maps.

12.3 The algebraic generating function

Define the polynomials $A(z), B(z), C(z)$ by

$$A(z) = \lambda\eta mr^2(\tau - \eta)z^3 \quad (80)$$

$$+ r\left(-(\lambda^2\eta m + m^2(m + r^2))\tau + (2m - 1)\lambda^2\eta^2 + \eta m^2(m + r^2) - \lambda r(m + r^2)\right)z^2 \quad (81)$$

$$+ \lambda\left(m^2r^2\tau - (m - 1)\lambda^2\eta^2 - m(m^2 + 2mr^2 - m - r^2)\eta + \lambda r^3\right)z \quad (82)$$

$$+ \lambda^2\eta m(m - 1)r, \quad (83)$$

$$B(z) = -\lambda^2\eta mr^2\tau z^3 \quad (84)$$

$$+ r\left((2\lambda^3\eta m + \lambda m^2(2m + r^2))\tau - (2m - 1)\lambda^3\eta^2 - \lambda\eta m^3 + \lambda^2r(2m + r^2)\right)z^2 \quad (85)$$

$$+ \lambda^2\left(-2m^2r^2\tau + 2(m - 1)\lambda^2\eta^2 + m(2m^2 + 2mr^2 - 2m - r^2)\eta - 2\lambda r^3\right)z \quad (86)$$

$$- 2\lambda^3\eta m(m - 1)r, \quad (87)$$

$$C(z) = -\lambda^2mr\left(\tau(\lambda^2\eta + m^2) + \lambda r\right)z^2 \quad (88)$$

$$+ \left(\lambda^3m^2r^2\tau + \lambda^4r^3 - \lambda^3\eta(m - 1)(\lambda^2\eta + m^2)\right)z \quad (89)$$

$$+ \lambda^4\eta m(m - 1)r. \quad (90)$$

The generating function is the formal-power-series branch of

$$A(z)G(z)^2 + B(z)G(z) + C(z) = 0 \quad (91)$$

12.3.1 Discriminant and residual genus-one curve

Define

$$J = \frac{\lambda\eta}{mr} + \frac{m^2}{\lambda r} + \frac{r^2}{m\eta} + \frac{\tau mr}{\lambda\eta}. \quad (92)$$

For the polynomials above, direct expansion and factorization give

$$B(z)^2 - 4A(z)C(z) = (\lambda^2\eta mr^2z)^2((1 - Jz + \tau z^2)^2 - 4z^3). \quad (93)$$

After removing the square factor and setting $X = z^{-1}$, the residual quadratic extension is birational to

$$E_J : \quad y^2 = (X^2 - JX + \tau)^2 - 4X. \quad (94)$$

Its smooth completion is a genus-one curve whenever

$$J^4\tau + J^3 - 8J^2\tau^2 - 36J\tau + 16\tau^3 - 27 \neq 0. \quad (95)$$

Indeed, the discriminant in X of the quartic on the right of (94) is 256 times the left-hand side of (95). The parameter J is also the first integral of the standard QRT dynamics for $\beta_n = H_{n-1}H_{n+1}/H_n^2$. The Somos-4 recurrence gives $\beta_{n-1}\beta_n^2\beta_{n+1} = \beta_n + \tau$; hence the map $(u, v) \mapsto (v, (v + \tau)/(uv^2))$ preserves $uv + u^{-1} + v^{-1} + \tau(uv)^{-1}$. Substitution of $u = \lambda r/m^2$ and $v = m\eta/r^2$ yields (92).

12.4 The two algebraic branches

With

$$D(z) = B(z)^2 - 4A(z)C(z),$$

the two algebraic branches may be represented by

$$G(z) = \frac{-B(z) \pm \sqrt{D(z)}}{2A(z)}. \quad (96)$$

When the constant term of A vanishes, the rationalized expressions

$$\frac{-2C(z)}{B(z) \mp \sqrt{D(z)}}$$

can be used instead. The sign in (96) cannot be fixed uniformly over the full parameter space.

Write

$$P(z, X) = A(z)X^2 + B(z)X + C(z).$$

The constant coefficients of (83)–(90) are

$$A_0 = \lambda^2 \eta m(m-1)r, \quad B_0 = -2\lambda^3 \eta m(m-1)r, \quad C_0 = \lambda^4 \eta m(m-1)r.$$

Consequently,

$$P(0, X) = A_0(X - \lambda)^2. \quad (97)$$

Both algebraic branches therefore coalesce at $X = \lambda$ when $z = 0$, and

$$\partial_X P(0, \lambda) = 2A_0\lambda + B_0 = 0. \quad (98)$$

The simple-root form of the formal implicit-function theorem is not applicable at the origin. When $m = 1$, the polynomial has a factor z , and the cancelled equation satisfies

$$\left. \frac{P(z, X)}{z} \right|_{z=0} = \lambda r^2(X - \lambda)((\lambda r + \tau - \eta)X - \lambda(\lambda r + \tau)).$$

Thus, generically, the second branch then has constant term $\lambda(\lambda r + \tau)/(\lambda r + \tau - \eta)$ rather than λ . In either case the desired branch is selected by the paired conditions $g_0 = \lambda$ and $g_1 = r$.

$$G(z) = \lambda + zF(z), \quad F(z) = \sum_{q \geq 0} f_q z^q, \quad f_q = g_{q+1}. \quad (99)$$

For

$$D_j = 2\lambda A_j + B_j, \quad E_j = \lambda^2 A_j + \lambda B_j + C_j,$$

where $C_3 = 0$, substitution into $P(z, G(z)) = 0$ gives

$$P(z, \lambda + zF) = \sum_{j=0}^3 E_j z^j + z \left(\sum_{j=0}^3 D_j z^j \right) F + z^2 \left(\sum_{j=0}^3 A_j z^j \right) F^2.$$

Equation (97) gives $E_0 = D_0 = 0$. An ordinary power-series branch additionally requires

$$E_1 = 0. \quad (100)$$

The next coefficient equation is

$$A_0 f_0^2 + D_1 f_0 + E_2 = 0. \quad (101)$$

The quadratic in (101) factors as

$$A_0 f_0^2 + D_1 f_0 + E_2 = \lambda^2 \eta m r (f_0 - r)((m-1)f_0 - m r). \quad (102)$$

Thus the prescribed value $f_0 = g_1 = r$ selects the required branch. When $m \neq 1$, the other slope is $m r / (m - 1)$.

12.5 The two-step companion

Let $G_{0;\ell,m,r,n,t}(x) = \sum_{q \geq 0} g_q x^q$ denote the selected solution. Its Hankel determinants satisfy

$$(H_1, H_2, H_3, H_4) = (\ell, m, r, n), \quad H_{q+4}H_q = H_{q+3}H_{q+1} + tH_{q+2}^2. \quad (103)$$

The next two values are

$$H_5 = \frac{mn + tr^2}{\ell}, \quad (104)$$

$$H_6 = \frac{rH_5 + tn^2}{m} = \frac{r(mn + tr^2) + t\ell n^2}{\ell m}. \quad (105)$$

Remove the first coefficient and shift the remaining series to the origin:

$$\widehat{G}(x) = \frac{G_{0;\ell,m,r,n,t}(x) - g_0}{x} = \sum_{q \geq 0} g_{q+1} x^q. \quad (106)$$

Its Hankel transform is

$$\det(g_{i+j+1})_{0 \leq i,j \leq q-1} = H_{q+2} \quad (q \geq 1). \quad (107)$$

It therefore begins with

$$r, \quad n, \quad \frac{mn + tr^2}{\ell}, \quad \frac{r(mn + tr^2) + t\ell n^2}{\ell m}, \dots$$

This is exactly the two-step advanced orbit $(H_{q+2})_{q \geq 1}$. It therefore satisfies the same recurrence with parameter t , starting at positive order $q \geq 1$. Equivalently, it has the initial parameter tuple

$$\left(r, n, \frac{mn + tr^2}{\ell}, \frac{r(mn + tr^2) + t\ell n^2}{\ell m}, t \right). \quad (108)$$

The assertion is an identity of Hankel transforms, not necessarily of the underlying coefficient sequences.

12.6 A recurrence for the coefficients

Using the notation of (99), division of the expanded quadratic equation by z^2 yields

$$A(z)F(z)^2 + (D_1 + D_2z + D_3z^2)F(z) + E_2 + E_3z = 0. \quad (109)$$

The branch condition is

$$A_0r^2 + D_1r + E_2 = 0, \quad (110)$$

and the branch is simple precisely when

$$2A_0r + D_1 \neq 0. \quad (111)$$

Equivalently,

$$(2A_0r + D_1)^2 = D_1^2 - 4A_0E_2. \quad (112)$$

Define

$$U_q = \sum_{k=0}^q f_k f_{q-k}, \quad U_q = 0 \quad (q < 0). \quad (113)$$

Coefficient extraction from (109) gives

$$\sum_{j=0}^3 A_j U_{q-j} + D_1 f_q + D_2 f_{q-1} + D_3 f_{q-2} + E_{q+2} = 0, \quad (114)$$

where $f_q = 0$ for $q < 0$ and $E_j = 0$ for $j > 3$. For $q \geq 1$,

$$U_q = 2rf_q + \sum_{k=1}^{q-1} f_k f_{q-k}. \quad (115)$$

Under condition (111), the coefficients are therefore generated recursively by

$$f_q = -\frac{A_0 \sum_{k=1}^{q-1} f_k f_{q-k} + \sum_{j=1}^3 A_j U_{q-j} + D_2 f_{q-1} + D_3 f_{q-2} + E_{q+2}}{2A_0 r + D_1}. \quad (116)$$

This quadratic convolution recurrence follows directly from the algebraic generating-function equation. On the selected branch,

$$2A_0 r + D_1 = -\lambda^2 \eta m r^2, \quad (117)$$

so condition (111) holds throughout the nondegenerate S-fraction chart. Because F is algebraic of degree at most two, it is D-finite. Consequently, the same coefficient sequence also satisfies a fixed-width linear recurrence with polynomial coefficients in the index.

12.7 Base field and nondegeneracy

The generic construction is over the rational-function field $\mathbb{Q}(\lambda, m, r, \eta, \tau)$. For scalar specializations, the initial conditions require at least

$$\lambda m r \eta (m \eta + \tau r^2) \neq 0,$$

together with the nonvanishing of every later Hankel quantity that occurs as a denominator. Accordingly, every reconstruction and uniqueness statement in this paper is understood within this nondegenerate S-fraction chart.

12.8 Nonuniqueness of the coefficient sequence

The ordinary Hankel transform does not, in general, determine a coefficient sequence. If only (H_n) is prescribed, the factorization $c_{2j-1}c_{2j}$ visible in (58) leaves room for variation in the individual Stieltjes coefficients. For this reason a five-parameter algebraic generating function should not be read as the unique moment representation attached to an ordinary Somos-4 Hankel orbit.

The construction in this paper removes this ambiguity by imposing the additional companion condition (56). In other words, we prescribe two product sequences: the first is the Somos-4 sequence (H_n) , and the second is the same sequence advanced by two determinant indices. Together with $c_0 = \lambda$, these two prescriptions determine the odd and even Stieltjes coefficients separately through (62) and (64). Hence the algebraic generating function in Section 12.3 is the fully specified representative selected by those two Hankel-level requirements. This choice is already built into the initial Stieltjes coefficients above; making it explicit here clarifies how the apparent degree of freedom is eliminated.

Other moment sequences can still share the first ordinary Hankel transform when the companion condition is not imposed. For example, the binomial transform, a standard Hankel-transform-preserving operation [29, 21],

$$g'_q = \sum_{k=0}^q \binom{q}{k} g_k, \quad (118)$$

has generating function

$$G'(z) = \frac{1}{1-z} G\left(\frac{z}{1-z}\right)$$

and preserves the Hankel determinants. Scalar and exponential rescalings of coefficient sequences produce explicit normalization factors in the determinants, while affine changes of the underlying variable give further related moment functionals. Equality of Hankel transforms must therefore not be replaced by equality of generating functions without an independent argument.

13 Symplectic Elliptic Dynamics of the Jacobi Coefficients

Assume that the Hankel determinants a_n satisfy $A(p_1, p_2)$, and let $u_n = \widehat{b}_n = a_{n-1}a_{n+1}/a_n^2$. By Section 10,

$$u_{n+2} = \frac{p_4 u_{n+1} - p_1}{u_{n+1}^2} - u_n, \quad (119)$$

which defines the birational map

$$T(x, y) = \left(y, \frac{p_4 y - p_1}{y^2} - x \right). \quad (120)$$

Define

$$I(x, y) = x^2 y^2 - p_4 x y + p_1(x + y) + p_2. \quad (121)$$

Proposition 12. *The polynomial I is invariant under T : $I(T(x, y)) = I(x, y)$. Consequently, every level set $C_K : I(x, y) = K$ is invariant.*

Proof. Set $z = (p_4 y - p_1)/y^2 - x$. Then $x + z = (p_4 y - p_1)/y^2$, and

$$I(y, z) - I(x, y) = (z - x)(y^2(z + x) - p_4 y + p_1) = 0.$$

□

Proposition 13. *The map T preserves the standard symplectic form $\omega = dx \wedge dy$. Equivalently, $\det DT(x, y) = 1$ where T is defined.*

Proof. Writing $T(x, y) = (y, z)$ gives

$$DT(x, y) = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ -1 & -p_4/y^2 + 2p_1/y^3 \end{pmatrix},$$

whose determinant is 1.

□

Corollary 14. *With respect to the canonical Poisson bracket, T is a Poisson map.*

Proposition 15. *The inverse is*

$$T^{-1}(x, y) = \left(\frac{p_4 x - p_1}{x^2} - y, x \right). \quad (122)$$

Moreover, T is reversible: if $\rho(x, y) = (y, x)$, then $\rho \circ T \circ \rho = T^{-1}$.

13.1 The invariant elliptic pencil

For a fixed K , the equation of C_K is

$$x^2 y^2 + (p_1 - p_4 x)y + p_1 x + p_2 - K = 0. \quad (123)$$

Introduce $z = 2x^2 y + p_1 - p_4 x$. Completing the square gives

$$z^2 = -4p_1 x^3 + (p_4^2 - 4p_2 + 4K)x^2 - 2p_1 p_4 x + p_1^2. \quad (124)$$

Theorem 16. *If the cubic on the right has no repeated root, the smooth projective completion of C_K is a curve of genus one, birational to the displayed cubic model.*

13.2 Involutions and QRT structure

Define

$$\iota_s(x, y) = (y, x), \quad \iota_v(x, y) = \left(x, \frac{p_4x - p_1}{x^2} - y\right).$$

Then $T = \iota_v \circ \iota_s$. Consequently, T is a symmetric QRT-type map associated with the biquadratic pencil C_K , in the sense of Quispel, Roberts, and Thompson [8].

13.3 A commuting elliptic Hamiltonian flow

Since T preserves both the symplectic form and I , consider

$$\dot{x} = \frac{\partial I}{\partial y}, \quad \dot{y} = -\frac{\partial I}{\partial x}. \quad (125)$$

Explicitly,

$$\dot{x} = 2x^2y - p_4x + p_1, \quad \dot{y} = -2xy^2 + p_4y - p_1. \quad (126)$$

Under the substitution above, $\dot{x} = z$ and the flow is elliptic. Since T is symplectic and $I \circ T = I$, T commutes with the Hamiltonian flow wherever both sides are defined.

14 Zero-Diagonal Prefix Convergents and Recovery of the Jacobi Orbit

We now exploit the freedom in the diagonal Jacobi coefficients by making the specific choice

$$\hat{d}_n = 0 \quad (n \geq 0).$$

This is not claimed to describe every moment functional covered by the characterization theorem. It selects a particularly tractable and mathematically interesting representative for which the relation between the Somos orbit and the prefix convergents can be examined directly.

Put $z = x^2$ and abbreviate $b_n = \hat{b}_n$. Consider the finite prefix convergents

$$C_n(z) = \frac{1}{1 - \frac{b_1z}{1 - \frac{b_2z}{\ddots - \frac{b_nz}{1}}}}, \quad C_0(z) = 1. \quad (127)$$

Thus all the C_n are prefixes of one and the same formal continued fraction. Let $Q_n(z)$ denote the corresponding denominator continuants, normalized by

$$Q_{-1}(z) = Q_0(z) = 1, \quad Q_n(z) = Q_{n-1}(z) - b_nzQ_{n-2}(z). \quad (128)$$

In particular, $Q_n(0) = 1$ for every n .

Proposition 17 (Successive-convergent difference). *For $n \geq 1$,*

$$C_n(z) - C_{n-1}(z) = \frac{(b_1b_2 \cdots b_n)z^n}{Q_n(z)Q_{n-1}(z)}. \quad (129)$$

Consequently, if

$$R_n(z) := \frac{C_n(z) - C_{n-1}(z)}{z(C_{n-1}(z) - C_{n-2}(z))} \quad (n \geq 2), \quad (130)$$

then the apparent singularity at $z = 0$ is removable and

$$R_n(z) = b_n \frac{Q_{n-2}(z)}{Q_n(z)}, \quad R_n(0) = b_n. \quad (131)$$

Proof. The standard continuant determinant identity, or a direct induction using (128), gives (129). Dividing its n th instance by z times its $(n-1)$ st instance gives

$$R_n(z) = \frac{b_1 \cdots b_n}{b_1 \cdots b_{n-1}} \frac{Q_{n-2}(z)}{Q_n(z)}.$$

Since every Q_j has constant term 1, evaluation at $z = 0$ proves the last claim. $\square$

This gives an exact answer to one part of the convergent-level question. The Jacobi coefficient is recoverable from three consecutive prefix convergents, not by their common value, but by the first normalized difference that has not yet stabilized.

Theorem 18 (Somos law for normalized convergent increments). *Assume that the shifted Hankel determinants satisfy the Somos-type relation, so that*

$$F(b_n, b_{n+1}) = 0, \quad F(X, Y) = X^2 Y^2 - p_4 XY + p_1(X + Y) + p_2.$$

Then, for every relevant n ,

$$F(R_n(0), R_{n+1}(0)) = 0, \tag{132}$$

where R_n is defined solely from four neighboring prefix convergents by (130). Equivalently,

$$F\left(\frac{C_n - C_{n-1}}{z(C_{n-1} - C_{n-2})}, \frac{C_{n+1} - C_n}{z(C_n - C_{n-1})}\right)\Big|_{z=0} = 0, \tag{133}$$

where both quotients are interpreted by removal of their singularities at $z = 0$.

Proof. By (131), $R_n(0) = b_n$ and $R_{n+1}(0) = b_{n+1}$. Substitution into the Jacobi biquadratic gives the claim. $\square$

The unnormalized differences tend to zero to successively higher orders, whereas division by the newly appearing power of z retains the Jacobi coefficient.

A useful approximation follows without evaluating the removable singularity exactly. From (128),

$$R_n(z) = b_n \left(1 + (b_{n-1} + b_n)z + O(z^2)\right). \tag{134}$$

Hence

$$F(R_n(z), R_{n+1}(z)) = O(z). \tag{135}$$

A first corrected estimator is

$$B_n^{[1]}(z) := \frac{R_n(z)}{1 + z(R_{n-1}(z) + R_n(z))}, \tag{136}$$

for which

$$B_n^{[1]}(z) = b_n + O(z^2), \quad F(B_n^{[1]}(z), B_{n+1}^{[1]}(z)) = O(z^2). \tag{137}$$

Thus finite evaluations of neighboring convergents provide systematically improvable approximations to the Jacobi orbit. This is useful when the convergents are available numerically or symbolically but extraction of their first non-stabilized coefficient is inconvenient.

There is also a direct error-amplitude interpretation. Since each additional level first contributes at order z^n , define

$$E_n := [z^n](C_n(z) - C_{n-1}(z)). \tag{138}$$

Equation (129) yields

$$E_n = b_1 b_2 \cdots b_n, \quad b_n = \frac{E_n}{E_{n-1}}. \tag{139}$$

Proposition 19 (Tau-function form of the convergent amplitudes). *Let $a_0 = 1$ and $b_n = a_{n-1}a_{n+1}/a_n^2$. Then*

$$E_n = \prod_{k=1}^n b_k = \frac{a_0 a_{n+1}}{a_1 a_n} = \frac{a_{n+1}}{a_1 a_n}. \quad (140)$$

Proof. The product telescopes, since every interior Hankel factor cancels. $\square$

Corollary 20.

$$p_4 = \frac{E_{n+1}}{E_{n-1}} + p_1 \left(\frac{E_{n-1}}{E_n} + \frac{E_n}{E_{n+1}} \right) + p_2 \frac{E_{n-1}}{E_{n+1}}. \quad (141)$$

Proof. Substitute $b_n = E_n/E_{n-1}$ in the first integral. $\square$

The Somos biquadratic is therefore equivalent to

$$\left(\frac{E_n}{E_{n-1}} \right)^2 \left(\frac{E_{n+1}}{E_n} \right)^2 - p_4 \frac{E_{n+1}}{E_{n-1}} + p_1 \left(\frac{E_n}{E_{n-1}} + \frac{E_{n+1}}{E_n} \right) + p_2 = 0. \quad (142)$$

This is a closed Somos-type law for the leading increments of successive prefix approximants.

Remark 21. The literal substitution $C_{n-1} = C_n = C_{n+1} = S$ is not the appropriate test for the zero-diagonal case, because it is performed before the first non-stabilized coefficient is resolved. Equations (133) and (142) show that the dynamics survives in the normalized confluence of the convergents. This does not yet give a scalar algebraic equation for $S(z)$ alone. It gives instead an exact hierarchy of constraints on the successive approximation layers by which the prefix convergents build $S(z)$. Any further scalar equation for S must be compatible with this refined limit rather than inferred from the unscaled diagonal specialization.

15 Unified Tau-Function Interpretation

The preceding constructions have a common tau-function description.

Theorem 22 (Equivalent projections). *For a nonzero sequence (a_n) with $a_0 = 1$, put*

$$b_n = \frac{a_{n-1}a_{n+1}}{a_n^2}, \quad E_n = \frac{a_{n+1}}{a_1 a_n}.$$

The Somos-4 recurrence for a_n , the QRT recurrence for b_n , the fixed biquadratic relation for consecutive b_n , and the amplitude relation (142) are equivalent wherever all quotients exist. For shifted Hankel determinants, b_n is the off-diagonal Jacobi coefficient; for zero-diagonal prefix convergents, E_n is the leading increment.

Proof. Divide the Somos recurrence by a_n^2 , use the conserved quantity (??), and finally substitute $b_n = E_n/E_{n-1}$. $\square$

Thus

$$\text{Hankel tau-functions } a_n \longrightarrow b_n \longrightarrow \text{QRT orbit and genus-one curve,} \quad E_n = \frac{a_{n+1}}{a_1 a_n}, \quad b_n = \frac{E_n}{E_{n-1}}.$$

In the inverse construction, J is the organizing invariant: it is computed from the initial Hankel data, equals the QRT first integral, and parametrizes the residual curve E_J from the algebraic discriminant. Determining an explicit birational identification with the Jacobi biquadratic remains a separate research problem.

16 Zero-Diagonal Jacobi Matrices and a Possible Volterra Lift

The diagonal Jacobi coefficients are not constrained by the Somos identity. One may therefore make the canonical choice $\widehat{d}_n = 0$, giving

$$\widehat{P}_{n+1}(t) = t\widehat{P}_n(t) - \widehat{b}_n\widehat{P}_{n-1}(t). \quad (143)$$

Then $\widehat{P}_n(-t) = (-1)^n\widehat{P}_n(t)$. After a choice of square roots $\alpha_n^2 = \widehat{b}_n$, the associated symmetric Jacobi matrix is zero-diagonal and bipartite. Such matrices are natural spectral operators for the Kac–van Moerbeke, or Volterra, hierarchy; see van Moerbeke [9] and Michor and Teschl [10]. In one standard normalization,

$$\dot{u}_n = u_n(u_{n+1} - u_{n-1}). \quad (144)$$

The present discrete evolution is reversible, symplectic, and preserves a pencil of genus-one curves, but a direct identification with the first Volterra flow should not be made without an additional argument. The contraction

$$u_n = \widehat{b}_n = c_{2n}c_{2n+1} \quad (145)$$

forgets the factorization into individual Stieltjes coefficients. Writing $c_{2n} = r_n$ and $c_{2n+1} = u_n/r_n$ exposes an additional multiplicative variable invisible in the projected Jacobi dynamics.

Conjecture 23. *There exists a lift of the birational Jacobi map $T(u_n, u_{n+1}) = (u_{n+1}, u_{n+2})$ to a birational transformation of the Stieltjes coefficients c_j such that:*

1. *the contraction $u_n = c_{2n}c_{2n+1}$ recovers T ;*
2. *the lifted transformation possesses a Lax or Darboux representation of Volterra or modified-Volterra type;*
3. *the biquadratic first integral I is obtained from a spectral invariant of the lifted transformation.*

The example A377264 is particularly suggestive in this context. A first step is to determine the translation point induced by T on the Weierstrass model. The paired-Hankel formulas then sharpen the second step: determine the induced map on the explicit Stieltjes coordinates in (67) and compare the resulting transformation with known Volterra and modified-Volterra Darboux maps.

References

- [1] T. S. Chihara, *An Introduction to Orthogonal Polynomials*, Gordon and Breach, 1978.
- [2] H. S. Wall, *Analytic Theory of Continued Fractions*, Chelsea, 1948.
- [3] M. E. H. Ismail, *Classical and Quantum Orthogonal Polynomials in One Variable*, Cambridge University Press, 2005.
- [4] P. Flajolet, Combinatorial aspects of continued fractions, *Discrete Mathematics* **32** (1980), 125–161.
- [5] S. Fomin and A. Zelevinsky, The Laurent phenomenon, *Advances in Applied Mathematics* **28** (2002), 119–144.
- [6] A. N. W. Hone and C. Swart, Integrality and the Laurent phenomenon for Somos–4 and Somos–5 sequences, *Mathematical Proceedings of the Cambridge Philosophical Society* **145** (2008), 65–85.

- [7] A. N. W. Hone, Continued fractions and Hankel determinants from hyperelliptic curves, *Communications on Pure and Applied Mathematics* **74** (2021), 2310–2347.
- [8] G. R. W. Quispel, J. A. G. Roberts, and C. J. Thompson, Integrable mappings and soliton equations, *Physics Letters A* **126** (1988), no. 7, 419–421.
- [9] P. van Moerbeke, The spectrum of Jacobi matrices, *Inventiones Mathematicae* **37** (1976), 45–81.
- [10] J. Michor and G. Teschl, On the equivalence of different Lax pairs for the Kac–van Moerbeke hierarchy, in *Modern Analysis and Applications: The Mark Krein Centenary Conference*, Operator Theory: Advances and Applications, vol. 191, Birkhäuser, 2009, pp. 445–453.
- [11] F. Liu, Y. Wang, and Z. Zhang, Hankel transform and (α, β) Somos–4 sequences, *arXiv preprint arXiv:2608.08703* (2026).
- [12] T. Scheuerle, Sequence A377264, *The On-Line Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences*, <https://oeis.org/A377264>, accessed 31 August 2026.
- [13] T. Scheuerle, Sequence A377441, *The On-Line Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences*, <https://oeis.org/A377441>, accessed 1 September 2026.
- [14] P. Barry, Generalized Catalan numbers, Hankel transforms and Somos–4 sequences, *Journal of Integer Sequences* **13** (2010), Article 10.7.2.
- [15] P. Barry, On a generalization of the Narayana triangle, *Journal of Integer Sequences* **14** (2011), Article 11.4.5.
- [16] P. Barry, Riordan–Bernstein polynomials, Hankel transforms and Somos sequences, *Journal of Integer Sequences* **15** (2012), Article 12.8.2.
- [17] P. Barry, Riordan pseudo-involutions, continued fractions and Somos–4 sequences, *Journal of Integer Sequences* **22** (2019), Article 19.6.1; arXiv:1807.05794.
- [18] P. Barry, Conjectures on Somos–4, 6 and 8 sequences using Riordan arrays and the Catalan numbers, arXiv:2211.12637 [math.CO], 2022.
- [19] X.-K. Chang, X.-B. Hu, and G. Xin, Hankel determinant solutions to several discrete integrable systems and the Laurent property, *SIAM Journal on Discrete Mathematics* **29** (2015), no. 1, 667–682.
- [20] X.-K. Chang and J. Liu, Hankel determinants from quadratic orthogonal pairs for hyperelliptic functions and their applications, arXiv:2603.11670v4 [nlin.SI], 2026; to appear in the *Journal of the London Mathematical Society*.
- [21] C. French, Transformations preserving the Hankel transform, *Journal of Integer Sequences* **10** (2007), Article 07.7.3.
- [22] D. Gale, The strange and surprising saga of the Somos sequences, *The Mathematical Intelligencer* **13** (1991), no. 1, 40–42.
- [23] I. M. Gessel and G. Xin, The generating function of ternary trees and continued fractions, *Electronic Journal of Combinatorics* **13** (2006), Research Paper 53.
- [24] A. N. W. Hone, Elliptic curves and quadratic recurrence sequences, *Bulletin of the London Mathematical Society* **37** (2005), 161–171.

- [25] A. N. W. Hone, Continued fractions and Hankel determinants from hyperelliptic curves, *Communications on Pure and Applied Mathematics* **74** (2021), no. 11, 2310–2347.
- [26] W. B. Jones and W. J. Thron, *Continued Fractions: Analytic Theory and Applications*, Encyclopedia of Mathematics and its Applications, vol. 11, Addison–Wesley, 1980.
- [27] C. Krattenthaler, Advanced determinant calculus, *Séminaire Lotharingien de Combinatoire* **42** (1999), Article B42q.
- [28] C. Krattenthaler, Advanced determinant calculus: a complement, *Linear Algebra and its Applications* **411** (2005), 68–166.
- [29] J. W. Layman, The Hankel transform and some of its properties, *Journal of Integer Sequences* **4** (2001), Article 01.1.5.
- [30] V. Ovsienko and E. Pedon, Continued fractions for q -deformed real numbers, $\{-1, 0, 1\}$ -Hankel determinants, and Somos–Gale–Robinson sequences, *Advances in Applied Mathematics* **162** (2024), Article 102788.
- [31] R. A. Sulanke and G. Xin, Hankel determinants for some common lattice paths, *Advances in Applied Mathematics* **40** (2008), 149–167.
- [32] A. J. van der Poorten and C. S. Swart, Recurrence relations for elliptic sequences: every Somos–4 is a Somos– k , *Bulletin of the London Mathematical Society* **38** (2006), 546–554.
- [33] H. S. Wall, *Analytic Theory of Continued Fractions*, Van Nostrand, New York, 1948.
- [34] Y. Wang and Z. Zhang, A sufficient condition for (α, β) Somos–4 Hankel determinants, *Discrete Mathematics* (2024); arXiv:2305.05995.
- [35] G. Xin, Proof of the Somos–4 Hankel determinants conjecture, *Advances in Applied Mathematics* **42** (2009), 152–156.